United States and Geo-technology: Electoral losses for data centers will have moderate impact on buildout

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【メール原文】

Data centers were a losing issue but blunt moratoria are unlikely.||||||||||||||||

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What Happened

Data centers were a significant issue in the 3 November midterms (see note). Voters elected governors in Texas, Ohio, and Georgia who campaigned on restricting buildouts. Where measures concerning data centers appeared on the ballot, voters mostly pushed for more restrictions or for a rejection of rezoning measures. Several incumbents seen as favorable to data centers lost.

Our Take

Local voters opposed data centers nearly everywhere the question appeared on a ballot. In Ohio, a major hub for data center development, the vast majority of local rezoning ballot measures for data centers failed. That indicates that developers will struggle to secure local zoning approval, even without more aggressive limits. Municipal restrictions will continue, but they fragment the map rather than halt the buildout in any state. To date, municipal restrictions have pushed data center developers to move projects to friendlier jurisdictions within the state, rather than closing any state. These restrictions will constrain the buildout only where they overlap with the connectivity, power, and water on which projects already depend.

Gina Hinojosa’s defeat of Greg Abbott in Texas is the most impactful single race for data centers. Roughly one-third of the planned US buildout is in Texas. While she campaigned on a moratorium until the legislature regulates data centers, she has limited powers to take executive action. Instead, she is likely to extend Abbott’s halt on new grid interconnections but cannot impose additional restrictions on her own. She will likely work with a split state legislature after the midterms to roll back tax incentives and write conditional restrictions in state law, especially strengthening local veto powers. Democrats also flipped the governorships in Georgia and Ohio, where both candidates ran against data centers. Georgia now has more planned capacity than Virginia, and its governor-elect has promised a temporary pause.

Governors will likely push conditions rather than blunt moratoria. Polling indicates that the issue did not decide many elections, but the results send a clear enough message that many incumbents will likely distance themselves from data centers regardless. That shift points to more measures and tighter conditions, such as environmental requirements, labor and wage standards, and community benefit

agreements. Multiple winning candidates support stronger actions and will likely support legislation in the coming state sessions, although the practical effect will be limited in some cases. Conditionality was already the direction of travel. These results will emphasize that direction, though pressure could eventually ease should utility affordability improve.

Increasingly stringent conditions and incentive rollbacks will raise costs, redirect data center projects to friendlier states, and slow the pipeline from proposals to operational capacity across states. In the few cases where states enact moratoria, these bans will be temporary in nature to create space for regulation to catch up to the buildout, which will slow the buildout but will not halt it.

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